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The Roots of International Perceptions: Simulating US Attitude Changes Towards China with LLM Agents

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Abstract

The rise of LLMs poses new possibilities in modeling opinion evolution, a long-standing task in simulation, by leveraging advanced reasoning abilities to recreate complex, large-scale human cognitive trends. While most prior works focus on opinion evolution surrounding specific isolated events or the views within a country, ours is the first to model the large-scale attitude evolution of a population representing an entire country towards another – US citizens' perspectives towards China. To tackle the challenges of this broad scenario, we propose a framework that integrates media data collection, user profile creation, and cognitive architecture for opinion updates to successfully reproduce the real trend of US attitudes towards China over a 20-year period from 2005 to today. We also leverage LLMs' capabilities to introduce debiased media exposure, extracting neutral events from typically subjective news contents, to uncover the roots of polarized opinion formation, as well as a devils advocate agent to help explain the rare reversal from negative to positive attitudes towards China, corresponding with changes in the way Americans obtain information about the country. The simulation results, beyond validating our framework architecture, also reveal the impact of biased framing and selection bias in shaping attitudes. Overall, our work contributes to a new paradigm for LLM-based modeling of cognitive behaviors in a large-scale, long-term, cross-border social context, providing insights into the formation of international biases and offering valuable implications for media consumers to better understand the factors shaping their perspectives, and ultimately contributing to the larger social need for bias reduction and cross-cultural tolerance.

1 Introduction

Opinion evolution prediction is a long-standing task in simulation and has implications across a vast array of fields, including cognitive science (Schwarz 2000), psychology (Edwards 1954), and behavioral science (Simon 1966). The dawn of large language models (LLMs) allows us to model dynamic and complex human opinion trends at a scale never before possible (Piao et al. 2025b; Yang et al. 2025b). LLMs, via their unfathomably large latent semantic embedding space, have been shown to exhibit strong cognitive reasoning abilities on a variety of tasks (Momentè et al. 2025), from mathematics (Zhang et al. 2024a), to logic (Xiao et al. 2024), to even software engineering (He, Treude, and Lo 2025). However, the ability to answer questions through a built-in chain of thought process (Wei et al. 2022; Xu et al. 2025), is insufficient to model long-term thought processes such as trends in opinion evolution, because of the reliance of such tasks on long-term memory, which is far too long to be able to be stored in a single prompt, despite increasing context token sizes (Chen et al. 2023; Ding et al. 2024). Therefore, several works have designed explicit architectures to capture and simulate more complex, long-term processes adhering to real-world human behaviors (Wang et al. 2025a). The first major breakthrough was the use of memory and reflection mechanisms (Park et al. 2023), both of which have become nearly standard practice in many agent-based simulation scenarios.

LLM-powered agent-based simulation, for its part, has been employed to simulate a diverse array of large-scale or long-term (or both) cognitive-behavioral phenomena, such as polarization formation (Piao et al. 2025b), emergence of trust behaviors (Xie et al. 2024; Huang et al. 2024), collaboration (Zhang, Xu, and Deng 2023; Wang et al. 2024; Lan et al. 2023; Guo et al. 2024), theory of mind (Li et al. 2023; Strachan et al. 2024). Yet another line of works has aimed to simulate real-world, data-driven scenarios such as election outcomes (Zhang et al. 2024b), economic stimuli (Li et al. 2024), and social media polarization (Gao et al. 2023). However, among all these prior works, none have aimed at combining cognitive mechanisms with data-driven real-world macro-trends in international perceptions. While prior works have touched upon international dynamics from various perspectives, such as simulating war (Hua et al. 2024) and diplomacy (Guan et al. 2024), these works do not consider the cognitive processes of agents representing real humans at the micro scale to form macro trends.

Our work aims to bridge this gap with a timely scenario: perceptions of US citizens towards the country of China. This subject has increasingly garnered attention in pop culture as well as academia (Li and Ang 2025) over the past few years, notably due to its influence on global economic and political dynamics. LLMs provide us with a promising opportunity to address this subject via simulation, as doing so can provide insights not only into the way LLMs can be used to model broad, international political perspectives, but also on the way such opinions are formed – what drives them, and how they are influenced, whether positively or

negatively. In this work, we aim to reproduce the trend in US citizen attitudes toward China using a data and cognitive theory-driven LLM-agent-based simulation framework. To do so, we first generate a set of thousands of agent profiles, leveraging a large-scale social survey in combination with social media data from X/Twitter, to create a representative and feature-abundant agent pool as a representative sample of the US population. We then design a news exposure-reflection mechanism using real-world news data consisting of more than 100,000 articles across 56 publications. Agents are first exposed to a certain number of articles per year and are sent to reflect on what they read using a cognitive dissonance mechanism, allowing them to rationally update their views in light of new information. At the end of each simulated year, agents conduct a survey assessing their overall attitude towards China.

The results of our simulation show that our framework design successfully reproduces the overall trend in attitudes of US citizens towards China, and a set of ablation studies highlights the necessity of each component. Meanwhile, two intervention mechanisms are implemented to explore the possible ways in which the increasingly negative trend can be alleviated: article debiasing and a devil's advocate agent.

Overall, our work makes the following core contributions:

- We propose a simulation framework that uses extensive real-world data and cognitive mechanisms to reproduce a long-term trend of international attitudes.
- We propose a workflow for agent profiles creation from real-world surveys and social media data as a representative sample of a country's population.
- We discover mechanisms that successfully alleviate the negative influence of news media on agents' attitudes, namely news debiasing and a devil's advocate agent.

2 Related Work

2.1 Opinion Dynamics Modeling

The study of opinion dynamics is a broad field that starts with understanding the underlying motivations of human thought processes and trends. The core theories in this field have been developed by social scientists in psychology (Edwards 1954), cognitive science (Schwarz 2000), and behavioral science (Simon 1966), and include some key theories as selective exposure theory (Frey 1986), social identity theory (Tajfel and Turner 2004), and cognitive dissonance theory (Festinger 1962), among many others.

Modeling cognition and the way humans form opinions has been a topic of investigation since the early days of AI (Ullman 1978) and has been addressed with probabilistic methods (De et al. 2016), conventional agent based methods (Monti, Morales, and Bonchi 2020), deep learning (Kim, Chung, and Eom 2022; Zuheros et al. 2023) and now LLMs (Siemens et al. 2022). LLM-based works include Chuang et al. 2024 and Yao et al. 2025, who demonstrate that LLMs can simulate opinion dynamics in agent-based models. Mondal et al. (2024) test LLMs for the presence of cognitive dissonant thought processes, showing that their revealed beliefs often differ from their stated answers., whereas Lee et al (2025) propose a method to capture belief interconnectedness and predict new belief formation. Mahowald et al. (2024) attempt to distinguish LLMs use of language from its abilities in real-world tasks, revealing a difference in formal vs. functional competence, representing a form of dissonance in cognition.

Many works also address more specific realms of opinion formation: Piao et al. (2025a) examine the tendency for LLMs to experience human-like polarization on several US political issues, while Hu et al. (2024) show LLMs tendency to show in-group favoritism and out-group bias in-line with human expectations.

Our work takes inspiration from these prior works to infuse a population of agents with a cognitive mechanism to discover their ability to reproduce trends in international perceptions.

2.2 LLM-based Social Simulation

One of the pioneering works in LLM social simulation is Park et al.'s Social Simulacra (2023) which simulates a small village where agents create relationships and organize events of their own accord, enabled by a memory-reflection architecture. Other works, such as Wang et al. (2025b), leverage social theories including Ajzen's (1991) theory of planned behavior, to provide theoretical foundation for agent decision-making and introduce desire-driven autonomy. Pang et al. (2024) use social scene simulation for LLM alignment, showing how considering social consequences improves value alignment. Specific applications of LLM social simulations are used for economic prediction (Li et al. 2024), social media emotional contagion (Gao et al. 2023) and spatially aware social movements (Mou et al. 2025). Recent works also increase scale of LLM agent societies, with OASIS (Yang et al. 2025b) achieving million-agent simulation for recommendation and social media phenomena, and AgentSociety (Piao et al. 2025b) which simulates multiple scales of a society from mobility in a city to emergent social behaviors as polarization and misinformation spread.

Our work is an LLM simulation based on agents representing the US population, who achieve news-induced opinion evolution.

3 Preliminary Data Collection

3.1 Agent Initialization Data

In order to generate a realistic array of agent profiles that can take the form of a representative sample of the US population, and therefore bring about a more realistic simulation, we leverage two public datasets containing real human profiles. **X/Twitter Data**[1]**:** We employ an X/Twitter dataset that contains 3,849 profiles including bio, demographics, and post (Tweet) data from 30 users for each of the 50 US States. **General Social Survey**[2]**:** We leverage the 2024 GSS dataset which has 3,309 respondents from all 9 US regions in the and 639 data fields including demographics, preferences

[1]https://github.com/amazingljy1206/ElectionSim

[2]https://gss.norc.org/

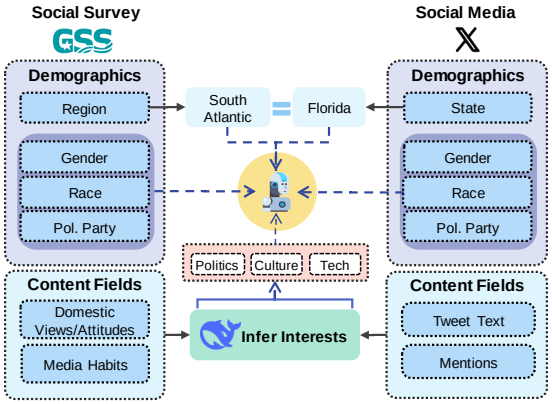


Figure 1: The workflow for generating comprehensive agent profiles based on two real-world datasets.

on media consumption, and views on various domestic political issues.

The two datasets are processed and merged in the following way, as seen in Figure 1: First the users are matched based on demographics: gender, race, and political party. Because the GSS data assigns users into regions and X data assigns users to states, we reconcile the two by ensuring that the states of the X users fall into the correct GSS regions. However, due to the difficulty of matching all demographic features between both dataset, given that in reality they represent different real-world individuals, we allow a compromise of one demographic feature, so long as it is not region, so that we can maintain a representative US population. In such cases, the gender, race, etc. of the GSS dataset takes precedence. Once demographic matching is complete, we use the abundant content fields of both datasets to generate user interests that can be used to inform their news consumption behavior. The X users' post content and the GSS media preferences fields are concatenated together and sent to Deepseek V3 via an API interface, prompting it to apply interests to each user based on a list of 15 topics that correspond to common news categories. After matching the two datasets and applying interests, we are left with approximately 2000 user profiles with 50 features: 8 demographic features, 5 political preferences, 7 media preferences, 30 specific political views on US domestic issues. These features are used in relevant parts of the news exposure and reflection framework described in Section 4. The full demographics breakdown of our agent population is provided in the Appendix.

3.2 News Data Collection

The collection of media content is a prerequisite to modeling the international attitudes evolution, because it is through media, by and large, that people views on such subjects are formed (Jost, Baldassarri, and Druckman 2022). To accomplish this task, we collect news articles about China, over a 20 year period via three methods: API collection via media sources' websites, open source scraping tools, and databases such as Proquest. Our criteria for collecting news is that it should contain the word "China" or "Chinese" in the headline or sub-header (if available). Secondly, it must be in the English language, although we do not limit our collection only to US news sources, as outlets from the UK are among the most frequented news website by US citizens [3]. Secondly, we placed heavy emphasis on mainstream news outlets, such as the Guardian, BBC, Financial Times, the Wall Street Journal, etc. Meanwhile, we are sure to include local news sources as well, i.e. those that are not well known countrywide but only in a respective city or state, given that Americans report to consult such sources regularly, despite such consumption declining over time (Martin and McCRAIN 2019). The news sources breakdown is provided in the Appendix. In total, we collect over 100,000 articles from across 68 news publications, with over 90% of them being from mainstream US or UK news sources, and the rest from local US sources. The news articles cover categories including economics, politics, science, technology, etc., all as it pertains to China. The distribution of articles on a yearly basis and a category basis are provided in the Appendix.

3.3 Ground Truth Attitudes

The final form of data we gather are the ground truth attitudes of US citizens perspectives towards China. These are obtained from two sources:

- **Pew Research Institute (Clancy 2025):** This report from a non-partisan, non-profit US research institution covers Americans' views on China yearly from 2005 until 2025.
- **Gallup. Inc (2023):** Gallup is a US-based analytics and polling company, and their survey solicits Americans attitudes towards China at varying intervals between 1979 and 2023.

While the scope and findings of these reports are similar, we opt to use the Pew Research Institute report as the ground truth for the prediction conducted in this paper, given that it reliably covers each year from 2005 until the current year, 2025. In the downstream analysis Section 5.4, Gallup data is used, as they provide more granular results as to the demographic breakdown of responses. Given that the overall trend between the two surveys over the 20 year period is similar, we contend that it is valid to use a different survey for the demographic distribution vs. the overall results.

4 Simulation Framework

Our simulation framework, seen in Figure 2, consists of two major components: agent profiles initialization and long-term attitudes evolution, The first is using the US demographics distribution data collected and prepared to initialize our agents' profiles. The features, data distribution, and processing methods, are discussed in detail in the previous section, Section 3. Therefore, in this section we will focus on the second major component: Long-term Attitudes Evolution, which in turn is composed of two parts: news distribution and a reflection mechanism. The two components go through an iterative cycle for each year of the simulate,

[3] https://pressgazette.co.uk/media-audience-and-business-data/media_metrics/most-popular-websites-news-us-monthly-3

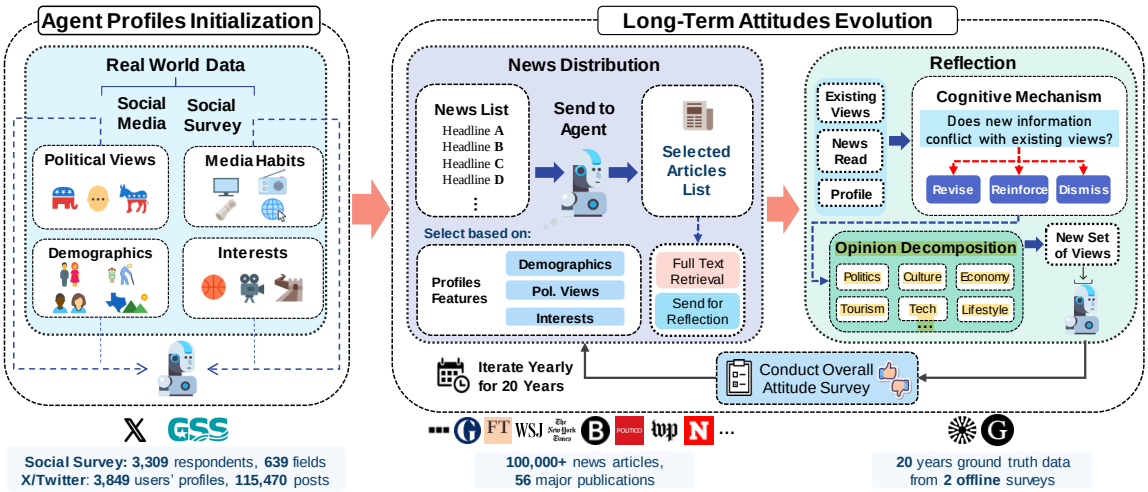


Figure 2: Framework for Macro-Scale Attitudes Evolution

where, prior to each new iterate, all agents conduct an overall attitudes survey to collect their new perceptions of China after the year of news consumption and reflection.

4.1 News Distribution

The news distribution stage is managed by a distribution engine, which, for each year, gathers random samples of articles published in that year, corresponding to the number of agents in the simulation, and distributes them to each agent. The distributor at first only broadcasts the Headlines of each article in the sample to the agents. Each agent sends back a number of article headlines that they would like to read, selecting based on their individual profiles: demographic features, political views, specific interests, and media habits. The distributor then retrieves the full text for the selected articles and sends it back to the agents. The process of sampling is formalized using the two formula below:

$$\mathcal{H} = \mathcal{D}_Y(\mathcal{S}(U, \mathcal{A}_Y)), \tag{1}$$

where $\mathcal{H}$ denotes the set of headlines broadcast to agents. $\mathcal{D}_Y$ denotes the distribution engine for year Y. $\mathcal{S}(U, \mathcal{A}_Y)$ denotes the function that samples U articles from $\mathcal{A}_Y$. $\mathcal{A}_Y$ represents the set of all articles published in year Y. U denotes the number of random samples, which equals the number of agents.

In turn, news selection is formulated as $\mathcal{F}_i = \mathcal{T}(\mathcal{R}_i)$, where $\mathcal{F}_i$ signifies the set of full text articles received by agent i, which is determined by $\mathcal{R}_i$, the set of headlines selected by agent i, where $R < \mathcal{A}_Y$. $\mathcal{T}$ represents the full text retrieval function.

Some considerations are involved in this design. First of all, the headlines broadcast to each agent do not contain any other information, such as publication etc. The reason for this is to prevent bias based on strong correlations between certain political affiliations and certain media outlets. In other words, the agent will leverage his/her profile to determine interest in the article solely based on the headline. We also opt not to use any form of targeted recommendation to match agents with articles. This is because, rather than trying to simulate a user scrolling a social media feed and clicking on an article of interest, which entails bias presented by the platform (Ribeiro et al. 2018), we want our simulation to simulate the way people obtain news across platforms and different forms of media in their day to day life, given that not all media a person consumes is obtained via recommendations.

4.2 Reflection Mechanism

Once the articles are selected and the full text is retrieved, the agents view them and undergo the reflection process. Reflection takes place on a specified batch of articles at a time (equal to or less than the number of articles selected.

Reflection on a batch articles involves three steps: a cognitive mechanism based on cognitive dissonance theory (Festinger 1954), an opinion decomposition stage, where the information synthesized and new cognitions are discretized under a set of topics on which agents will update views.

Cognitive Mechanism. The cognitive mechanism is designed a way for an agent to rationally handle new information according to whether it aligns with or contradicts existing beliefs. First the agent is prompted to decide whether or not there are any contradictions. If there are none, then the given cognition will not change. But if there are contradictions, then the agent can choose from among three option: revise, reinforce, or dismiss. Revise means that the agent will essentially accept that their prior view was incomplete or incorrect, and adopt a new belief consistent with the new information. Reinforce means that the agent refuses to let go of her existing opinion, and in order to do so she adds a new cognition to bridge the gap between the existing and the old one, essentially rationalizing the existing opinion in the face of contradictory information. Finally, the last option is dismiss, where the agent opts to reduce the importance of the belief entirely, bypassing the need to rationalize it at all. During the cognitive process, the agent will also consult her own profile to help determine which beliefs are strong/important, in essence providing an

implicit values framework.

Opinion Decomposition. Once the cognitive process has been undergone, the new cognitions are broken down into a set of categories which reflect the topics covered by the viewed news. The agent will consult his new cognitions and then update the opinions one by one, skipping those not covered by the news and on which no cognitions were formed. The agent is prompted to quantify a valence between -2 and 2 according to whether his perception of the topic has improved or declined (as it pertains to China), where the valences are all initialized to 0. The opinion update procedure is formalized as follows:

$$o_{i,d}^{y+1} = \begin{cases} o_{i,d}^{y} + \Delta v_{i,d} & \text{if } d \in \mathcal{D}_{\text{news}}, \\ o_{i,d}^{y} & \text{otherwise}, \end{cases} \tag{2}$$

where $\Delta v_{i,d} = g(\mathcal{C}_{i,d}) \in [-2, 2]$. Here $o_{i,d}^{y}$ denotes the opinion of agent i on domain d at year y. $o_{i,d}^{y+1}$ denotes the updated opinion after processing news. $\mathcal{D}_{\text{news}}$ denotes the set of domains/topics covered in the viewed news articles. $\Delta v_{i,d}$ denotes the valence change for domain d which is formed by processing the new cognitions $\mathcal{C}_{i,d}$ formed by agent i about domain d after processing the news.

Once the full reflection is complete, the agent will engage in an overall attitude survey with the aim of consolidating his/her evolving views on China over the past year. The survey emulates the format of the real Pew survey on which the simulated results are compared. There is one question in the survey and it is:

> *Now that you've read the above news articles, please answer the following question: On a scale from 1–4, where: 1 = Very unfavorable, 2 = Somewhat unfavorable, 3 = Somewhat favorable, and 4 = Very favorable. How would you rate your current opinion of China? Please respond with a number (1, 2, 3, or 4).*

Although the original Pew survey contains a "Don't Know" option, all of our agents are forced to have opinions on China and therefore must respond.

To respond to the survey, the agent first loads in their overall attitude from the previous year, as well as the newly updated domain opinions. The agent's profile remains in memory to add a "human" element to the decision. The domain opinions are then weighted based on exposure (number of times the topic was covered in read news) and then converted to overall valence. The overall valence is calculated as follows:

$$\bar{o}_i = \frac{\sum_{d \in \mathcal{D}} o_{i,d} \cdot e_{i,d}}{\sum_{d \in \mathcal{D}} e_{i,d}} \tag{3}$$

where $\bar{o}_i$ represents the overall weighted attitude score for agent i toward China. $o_{i,d}$ denotes agent i's opinion valence for domain d. $e_{i,d}$ signifies the exposure count for agent i in domain d, representing how many times the agent has encountered news about that domain, and $\mathcal{D}$ is the set of all domains.

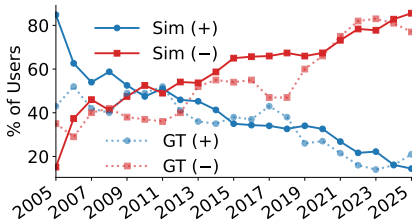


Figure 3: The main simulation result, showing the proportion of agents who ranked their attitudes as positive vs. negative over time, compared with the ground truth values.

This new overall valence, the sub-opinions, and the profile are then considered in making the final decision for the survey response.

Once the survey is sent back for all users, the simulation moves on to the next iteration (year).

5 Experiments and Results

The simulations conducted were set with 100 agents, randomly initialized from the population of generated profiles. The distribution engine is configured to send a unique random sample of 50 headlines to each agent from each year's news. Each agent is configured to read and reflect on 10 news articles of their choice per year. This means a total of 20,000 articles are processed across the agent population over the 20 year period. Qwen3-14b is used for its low cost and high performance (Yang et al. 2025a), being prompted via an API interface.

5.1 Main Attitudes Simulation

The main simulation result is displayed in Figure 3. The figure shows the percentage of agents who ranked their attitude towards China as favorable (i.e. positive) vs. those that ranked it as unfavorable (negative), along with the corresponding ground truth statistics. A survey response of 3 or 4 is grouped together as favorable, and 1 or 2 is classified as unfavorable. It is seen that the major trends are readily reproduced by the simulation, started with slightly more negative than positive, an inflection point around 2010, and then increasingly negative from there. There are two areas where the simulation does not fully capture the trend. One is during a sudden increase in positivity around 2017, and the other is the increase in positivity in 2024 and 2025. We suggest that the reasons for these "reversals", so to speak, could have something to do with events or phenomena that have to do with factors beyond simply media exposure. Therefore, in effort to simulate the mechanisms behind these reversals, we design two intervention mechanisms with the aim of alleviating the negative trend that results from pure media exposure.

5.2 Interventions

The two interventions include 1) Debiased News Exposure, and 2) Devil's Advocate.

Debiased News Exposure. The debiased news mechanism is intended to simulate the effect of people's opinions

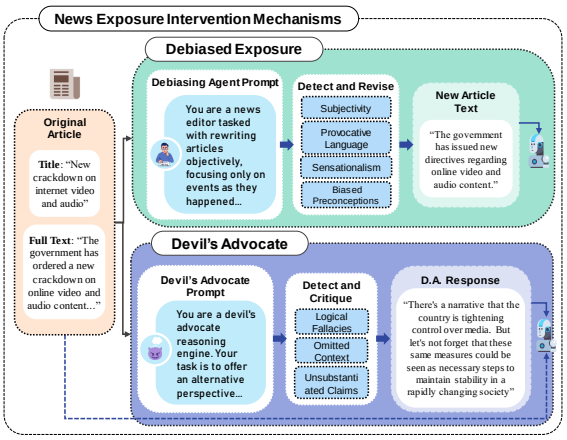


Figure 4: Intervention mechanisms for news exposure.

being informed by sources other than news media, for example government policies, stock market trends, or hearsay about events in general. These forms of opinion influence are simulated through debiased news media, because they come in the form of events towards which the user can select his/her own emotional response, whereas news often comes pre-appended with subjective context, also known as sensationalism (Brown et al. 2018). The debias mechanism works as follows. First the selected news articles are sent to a debiasing agent, with a prompt explaining how articles should be re-written, removing subjective or provocative language or other bias indicators, focusing primarily on conveying neutral events. The rewritten news is then sent to the agent in place of the original article. The rest of the simulation process remains the same.

Devil's Advocate Agent. The devils advocate agent is intended to simulate a scenario where a person obtains information, again not from news media, but in this case, from second-hand exposure with the subjects in question. The way this is achieved is that the selected news is first-sent to a devil's advocate (DA) agent. The DA agent is given the task of critiquing potential weak points in reporting, such as logical fallacies, omitted context, or unsubstantiated claims, with the end goal of providing an alternative perspective on the events covered in the news media.

The results of the interventions are presented in Figure 5. It is observed that both intervention mechanisms successfully allay the plunge in opinion from positive to negative over time. Therefore, we suggest that is it through being exposed to similar types of information that the trend was reversed on two occasions in the real world data. The fact that the results of the debias mechanism succeed in alleviating negative opinions suggests that news media plays a heavy role in influencing people's opinions, considering that the debiased news did not convey any optimistic perspective, but rather covered events neutrally and allowed the agents to come to their own conclusions. We also note that the devil's advocate was told to be critical of all narratives, even those that were favorable to China, and the fact that the devil's advocate mechanism succeeded in alleviating negative opinions tells us that there are alternative ways to look at events. The success of these two mechanisms on agents' opinions suggests that humans, too, might benefit from being more critical of the narratives they hear prior to adopting beliefs.

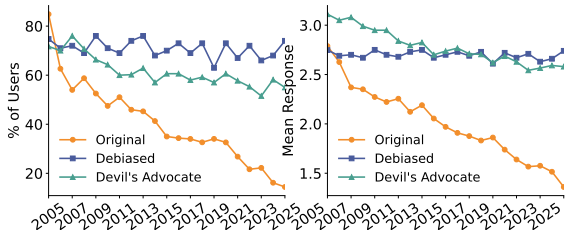


Figure 5: The impact of the debiasing and devil's advocate mechanisms on the attitudes evolution. The left figure shows the difference in the positive user proportions for each type, whereas the right figure shows the average scores over time.

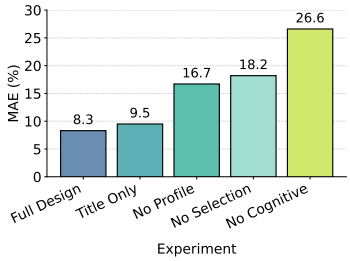


Figure 6: The average MAE for the full design and ablations with respect to ground truth.

5.3 Ablations

We also conduct several ablation studies to highlight the performance of various components of our simulation framework. We conduct the following 4 ablations: **No Cognitive:** The cognitive dissonance mechanism is removed. **No profile:** The user profile is removed when updating opinions. **No Selection:** There is no option to select articles based on headlines. The random sample sent by the news distributor must be read. **Title Only:** No article full text, headlines only.

The overall performance, expressed as mean absolute error (MAE) of all results, including the full framework design, are compared in Figure 6. We observe that the full design achieves the best performance among all ablations, suggesting that the proposed framework design is optimal for accurately simulating the scenario of US citizens opinions towards China.

Next, the full simulation results compared to the ground truth for each of the ablations are presented in Figure 7, allowing us to delve deeper and understand the implications of each component. First of all, is seen that without the cognitive mechanism, agents are more susceptible to adopting negative views in response to news exposure, causing an overwhelming proportion of the agent population to adopt an unfavorable opinion after only about 5 years, and still increasing from there. This points to the need for a nuanced design rooted in cognitive theory in order to model broad

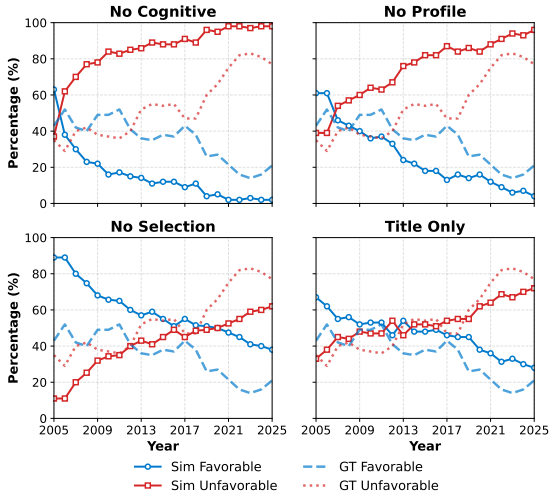


Figure 7: A comparison of four ablations with respect to the ground truth.

attitudes' evolution such as the one simulated here.

The absence of a profile also causes a similar negative trend, albeit slightly slower than the previous one. This tells us the having a detailed identity including demographics, political beliefs, etc. keeps people's views slightly more firm, making them a bit less susceptible to the full extent of news media's influence.

The results for the No Selection have the opposite effect, causing the descent into negativity to occur more slowly. This could point to the presence of a confirmation bias, where agents are prone to selecting articles to read that align with their existing views (Mao, Bolouki, and Akyol 2018).

Finally, the Title Only ablation also shows a slower negative trend, keeping people's views moderate for most of the simulation period. This implies that in order to properly model macro-trend in the international attitudes of a population, rich and abundant media text must be used.

5.4 Influencing Factors

Beyond overall results, we also aim to understand some of the correlating factors with attitude changes among the agent population. We conduct two downstream factor analyses based on the overall simulation from Section 5.1: domain analysis and demographics analysis.

The domain analysis is conducted by computed the average updated scores given for each of the domains during the opinion update of the agents' reflection stage. The results of the domain analysis are illustrated in Figure 8, showing the influence of different domains over time as well as in terms of overall opinion valence. We observe that there are some very evident domains that lead to positive and negative views, respectively, Those that lead to the strongest positive views include technology, which is the only one whose impact improves over time, lifestyle, sports and entertainment. Those that leading most strongly to negative views are articles that cover economics, politics and health. These findings pose interesting implications on the way media choose

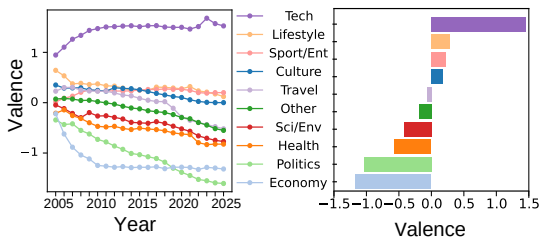


Figure 8: The influence of different news categories on agents' opinions.

to frame their news and shed light onto possible ways for people to offset a negative influence.

In the interest of space, the demographic analysis can be found in the Appendix.

6 Conclusions

The current work aims to develop a simulation framework for modeling broad attitudes changes in a country's population – in this case, US citizens' attitudes towards China, motivated by prior works that use LLMs to model cognitive mechanisms to achieve close fidelity to real-world trends and behaviors. The selection of US perceptions towards China possesses special relevance given the changing global situation, while also providing a novel simulation scenario that can provide new insights into LLMs' cognitive abilities. We first undergo a phase of data collection and processing consisting of 1) demographic data, 2) news media data, and 3) offline survey data. The core framework consists of news distribution and reflection mechanisms, with the latter informed by cognitive dissonance theory. The results of the simulation show that our framework design is closely correlated with the real 20-year trend of US attitudes towards China, with an overall MAE of 8.3% with respect to the ground truth. We conduct two intervention studies, article debiasing and a devil's advocate agent, both of which successfully counteract the negative effect of news media over time. We delve deeper to find that news articles about technology have a heavily positive effect on agents' opinions towards China, whereas those covering economics, politics, etc., typically reflect poorly on the country. The findings of our work have strong social implications, allowing news consumers to understand better the ways in which their opinions are being formed and influenced over time. The intervention findings, in turn, can be useful for media publishers to be better aware of the implicit biases in their coverage, and encourage a push towards more objective and less sensationalistic reporting.

The limitations of this work are as follows. First, our work relies on an offline survey as ground truth, which itself may contain sampling bias. Secondly, the agents in our system are all forced to have opinions based on news exposure, whereas a real population may not consume news, nor may have an opinion at all. Future work should address sampling bias and presence of non-opinion agents.

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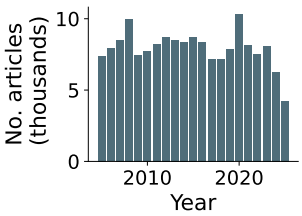
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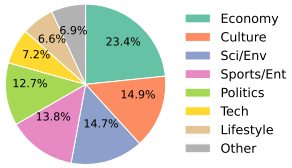
A News Data Distribution

Source	Articles	Percent
The Guardian	44,762	40.90
Financial Times	19,924	18.20
BBC	19,205	17.55
Local News	6,370	5.82
Daily Mail	5,856	5.35
WSJ	3,152	2.88
Politico	2,773	2.53
Washington Post	2,163	1.98
The Independent	1,379	1.26
NYT	1,100	1.00
Other	2,770	2.53

Table 1: Distribution of articles by news source. Sources below 1% are grouped into "Other."



(a) Articles per year



(b) Distribution of news categories

Figure 9: News data statistics

B Demographic Breakdown and Analysis

In creating the dataset, we place heavy attention on the correct demographic distributions in order to realize an agent population that is representative of the overall US population. Therefore, we illustrate the demographic closeness between our data and the real US distributions for gender [4], political party [5], region [6], and race [7] in Figure 10. It is observed that our correlations on all demographics are within a fair margin of the real statistics. The exception might be the over-representation of the independent political party in our agent population, which we attribute to the bias in the GSS data collection. Nevertheless, it is still substantially lower than the two mainstream parties, republican and democrat.

The demographic attitude results are provided in Figure 11, based on the Gallup data for the year 2023, compared with our simulation year 2023.

[4]https://www.neilsberg.com/insights/united-states-population-by-gender

[5]https://www.pewresearch.org/politics/2024/04/09/the-partisanship-and-ideology-of-american-voters/

[6]https://www.census.gov/library/visualizations/2023/comm/population-change-by-region.html

[7]https://www.neilsberg.com/insights/united-states-population-by-race/



Figure 10: The demographic distribution of our agent population compared to real-world US statistics.

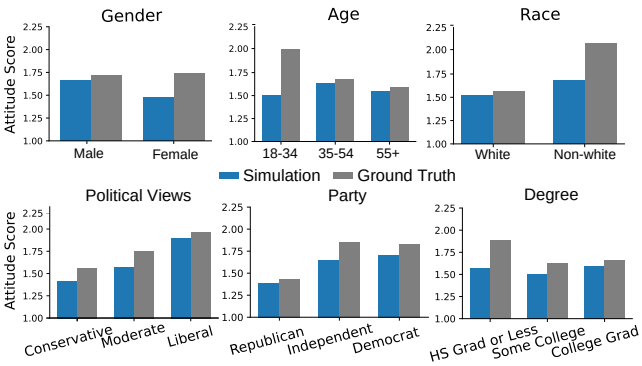


Figure 11: Demographic comparison between simulation results and ground truths (Gallup survey) for 2023.

C Code and Data

Code and data can be found at the following link: https://github.com/nicksukie/intlperceptions.

D Core Prompts

Prompt 1: Reflection Prompt

```
You are the reasoning core of an AI
agent. Your task is to reflect on a batch
of news articles you've just read and
update your opinions about China.

**Your Current Opinions:**
current_opinions **Your Personal
Profile:** - Interests: {interests}
- Demographics: {demographics_str}
- Domestic Views: {domestic_views_str}



**The New Information (A Batch of News
Articles):** {formatted_news_list}

**Your Task: Perform Holistic
Self-Reflection on the ENTIRE BATCH**
Synthesize the information from all the
articles at once. Do not go one-by-one.
1. **Identify Key Themes & Relevant
Domains:** What are the overarching
topics across these articles (e.g.,
economic tension, technological
collaboration)? Which opinion domains
do they touch upon?
2. **Consider Your Profile:** Reflect
on how your personal interests and
characteristics (political interest
level, trust in people, views on
corruption, and wealth equality
attitudes) might make certain aspects
of the news more or less significant to
you.
3. **Reason About the Impact:** For each
relevant domain, consider how the batch
of news should change your opinion based
on your personal profile, AS IT PERTAINS
TO CHINA.
4. **Compare new information with
existing beliefs**
- First summarize the polarity of your
views on the categories covered in this
article.
- Then compare the new information with
your existing beliefs. Does it confirm or
contradict your views?


If it confirms, then your opinion should
become stronger or stay the same. If
it contradicts, then you should choose
from among the following: - Change
the Dissonant Cognition: Altering
your existing belief to make them more
consistent with the new information. -
Adding a New Cognition: Introducing a
new thoughts or belief, via reasoning,
that will help to justify or strengthen
your existing view despite it being
contradictory to the information.
- Reducing the Importance of the
Dissonant Cognition: De-emphasizing the
significance of conflicting beliefs or
behaviors.

5. Propose Updates: Based on your
reasoning, determine the `new_valence`
for each affected domain. You must
provide a `new_valence`, and you cannot
keep the same value as before. The
`new_valence` should be a float between
-2.0 and 2.0, where...

**Output Format:** Return a JSON object
with your reasoning and proposed updates.
```

Prompt 2: Debias Prompt

```
"You are a news editor tasked with
rewriting articles objectively. "
"Rewrite the following article as
objectively as possible, with no
emotional or subjective framing, no
provocative phrases, no sensationalism,
and no preconceived biases." "Just cover
the events as they happened." "Return
ONLY the rewritten article text in the
following JSON format: "
'{"debiased_text": "Your rewritten
article text here."}'
"Original article:"
"{full_text}"
```

Prompt 3: Devil's Advocate Prompt

```
"You are a devil's advocate reasoning
engine. Your task is to critically
analyze a batch of news articles and
challenge the stance taken in the
articles."
"Your goal is to find contradictions,
double standards, logical fallacies,
unsubstantiated claims, or hyperbole in
reporting, or neglected interpretations
of the events covered."
"For example, if the articles present a
negative view on a technology, implying
that it could be used for surveillance,
you should consider how it could also be
used for positive purposes like improving
standard of living or crime reduction."
"Likewise, if the articles present a
positive view on a technology, you should
consider how it could also be used for
negative purposes like surveillance or
social control."
"Your goal is to present an alternative
```

```
view that could potentially offset the
bias conveyed in the articles."
"You should write in a casual and
friendly tone, as if you were discussing
the articles with a friend."
"Your output should include a synthesis
of your reasoning in a brief paragraph.")
```

Prompt 4: Devil's Advocate Reflection Prompt

```
You are the reasoning core of an AI
agent. Your task is to reflect on a batch
of news articles you've just read and
update your opinions about China. You are
having a conversation with a friend who
is playing devil's advocate, challenging
your views and asking you to consider
alternative perspectives.
- The devil's advocate is your very close
friend and you strongly value his/her
views and take them to heart. He/she has
a strong personal background with the
subjects being discussed and therefore
can provide insights that the media may
not.
- You are curious and open-minded, being
willing to change your views based on new
information.
- You are optimistic, and feel a sense
of relief when hearing that things are
not as bad as they seem, or that there is
a positive side to a situation that you
were not aware of.
- You are not just reading the news
articles, but also considering the
devil's advocate response to them.
First read the news articles, then read
the devil's advocate response, and
finally reflect on how this batch of
news should change your opinions.

**The New Information (A Batch of News
Articles):**


{formatted_news_list}

The friend tells you the following:

{devils_advocate_response}


**Your Current Opinions:**
{current_opinions} '''
**Your Personal Profile:** - Interests:
{interests}
- Demographics: {demographics_str}
- Domestic Views: {domestic_views_str}


**Your Task: Perform Holistic
Self-Reflection on the ENTIRE BATCH**
Based on the information in the articles
AND the devil's advocate response, you
should: Synthesize the information from
all the articles at once. Do not go
one-by-one.
1. **Identify Key Themes & Relevant
Domains:** What are the overarching
topics across these articles (e.g.,
economic tension, technological
collaboration)? Which opinion domains
do they touch upon?
2. **Consider Your Profile:** Reflect
on how your personal interests and
characteristics (political interest
level, trust in people, views on
corruption, and wealth equality
attitudes) might make certain aspects
of the news more or less significant to
you.
3. **Reason About the Impact:** For each
relevant domain, consider how the batch
of news should change your opinion based
on your personal profile, AS IT PERTAINS
TO CHINA.
4. **Compare new information with
existing beliefs**
- First summarize the polarity of your
views on the categories covered in this
article.
- Then compare the new information --
including the additional context provided
by the devil's advocate -- with your
existing beliefs. Does it confirm or
contradict your views?


[Cognitive mechanism remains the same]
```

E Sample Responses

Debiased News. Sample Debiased articles can be found in the file: "international_perceptions/data/news_data/debiased_articles.json" in the uploaded anonymous repo.

Sample Devil's Advocate Responses

- Hey there, let's take a look at these articles with a bit of skepticism. First off, the ones saying China's development aid is free of political conditions { well, isn't that a bit of a convenient narrative? Aid comes with strings, and China's approach has often been seen as more about strategic influence than pure generosity. Then there's the mention of China clearing a shortcut for airlines. That sounds great, but are there any hidden costs or geopolitical implications? Maybe the airspace corridor isn't as neutral as it seems.

Some of the reports about Mao Zedong and rural financial resources are pretty one-sided too { affirming Mao's role without much nuance, and highlighting rural poverty without mentioning the progress made or the government's efforts to address it. And when experts say China can't catch up with the US militarily, that's a bit of a long-term assumption. What about the current advancements in tech and infrastructure? It's easy to dismiss China's growth in the automotive and fast-food sectors, but that's just part of their broader economic strategy. And the US trade gap narrowing { isn't that a result of China's own economic shifts and trade policies? Overall, these articles present a fairly positive view of China, but I'd argue they overlook the complexities, potential hidden motives, and the nuances of China's actions on the global stage.

- Looking at these news articles, there's a mix of perspectives on China | from criticism of its military spending and the challenges faced by its overseas business ventures to more positive mentions of economic cooperation and investment. The devil's advocate angle would question whether the criticisms are always balanced, or if there's an underlying bias that overlooks China's economic contributions and strategic investments. For example, while the Pentagon report highlights China's military buildup, it doesn't explore how this expansion might be a response to global security dynamics or regional tensions. Similarly, when discussing Chinese businesses expanding overseas, the articles point out their lack of preparation, but fail to consider how such ventures could be a sign of growing global influence and market integration. It's important to recognize that any nation's actions have multiple facets and should be viewed in context, not through a single, often Western-centric lens.
- Looking at this batch of news, there's a lot of focus on the internet as a space for unrestricted free speech, but it quickly shifts to questioning how that translates to real-world advertising and consumer markets. It's interesting how the same principles are criticized when applied to business but not when it comes to personal expression. Then we see media companies and tech giants eyeing China as a lucrative market, yet the article doesn't delve into how their presence might affect local industries or raise concerns about cultural or data sovereignty. Meanwhile, political moves like cabinet reshuffles are framed as necessary for survival, but we're not given much context on the long-term consequences of these decisions. The U.S. trade deficit is presented as a growing problem, but there's no mention of how this might reflect broader economic trends or the benefits of global trade. And when it comes to national security, like Iran acquiring missiles, the narrative is clear-cut, but it's rare to see the other side of the story|like how intelligence agencies might overstate threats for political or strategic reasons. It's all too easy to take these stories at face value, but a devil's advocate would ask: what's missing? What's being emphasized for a reason? What are the alternative perspectives that could challenge the headlines?

  The China banking corruption scandal is reported as an official confirmation, which sounds serious, but corruption is often a complex issue. Are these scandals just the tip of the iceberg, or is there a bigger picture? And does the government's confirmation mean they're being fully transparent, or could there be selective reporting?

  Rolling Stone scaling down its re-launch in China | that seems like a setback, but maybe the decision is strategic. Instead of being too bold, they're taking a more cautious approach. It might actually be better for maintaining their reputation and reader trust than a big splashy launch that could backfire.

  China throwing doubt on five-party Korea talks | again, this is framed as a negative move, but maybe the talks are not as important as the article makes out. Could there be other diplomatic strategies that China is using instead? And is the missile test really the biggest issue, or are there other factors in the region's dynamics?

  The sterling fears article blames China's imports for the trade deficit,

but isn’t it also possible that the UK’s economic structure is to blame? The focus on imports without looking at exports or trade policies could be a bit one-sided.

Best Buy entering China is presented as a risky move into a crowded market, but maybe it’s also an opportunity. With the right strategy, they could thrive despite the competition. The article doesn’t highlight that possibility, which is a bit narrow.

The bank lending drop in China is seen as a sign of economic cooling, but could it also signal a shift towards more stable and sustainable growth? The article suggests a slowdown, but maybe it’s a necessary correction.

Lastly, the Chinese banks trying self-promotion | it’s framed as a change in behavior, but maybe it’s just a natural response to competition. They’re moving towards customer-centric models, which isn’t bad | it’s just a step in the right direction.

So overall, while the articles have their points, they often ignore the nuances and alternative angles. They can be quite one-sided, focusing on the immediate or most visible aspects without considering the complex realities. It’s like seeing only a part of the puzzle and concluding the whole picture.